Lesson 06: Commas

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 8.1: Commas.

In this lesson

You will learn the main uses of the comma: after introductory words, in lists, between coordinating adjectives, before a conjunction in a compound sentence, around interrupting words, in dates, addresses and letters, and before a quotation. Commas show the reader where to pause and which words belong together, so correct commas make your essays, e-mails and research papers easier to read and harder to misunderstand.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Put a comma after an introductory word or phrase.
- Separate the items in a list, and a string of coordinating adjectives, with commas.
- Join two independent clauses with a comma and a coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS).
- Set off interrupting words with commas.
- Punctuate dates, addresses, greetings, closings and quotations correctly.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
comma (,)	a mark that shows a pause or separates the things in a list	The barn, the tool shed, and the back porch were destroyed by the wind.
introductory word or phrase	a word or group of words before the main sentence	Ironically, she already had plans for that day.
serial comma	the comma before *and* (or *or*) and the last item of a list (series); also called the Oxford comma	olives, peppers, and pineapple chunks
coordinating adjectives	a string of adjectives that describe the same noun	It was a bright, windy, clear day.
independent clause	a subject and a verb that can stand alone as a sentence	he is still very tired
coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS)	for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so	He says his fever is gone, but he is still very tired.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
compound sentence	a sentence made of two independent clauses	The bedroom door was closed, so the children knew their mother was asleep.
interrupting words	extra words that are not essential for the sentence to make sense	I knew where it was hidden, of course, but I wanted them to find it themselves.
greeting / closing	the words before the message, and before your signature, in a letter or e-mail	Dear Mrs. Al-Sayf, / Sincerely,
block quotation	a quotation of 40 words or more, on new lines and indented, with no quotation marks	(common in research papers)

Rules and explanations

1. After an introductory word or phrase

The comma shows where the introduction ends and the main sentence begins.

- Without spoiling the surprise, we need to tell her to save the date.
- Ironically, she already had plans for that day.

2. In a list

Put a comma after each item, then *and* before the last item. There is no comma after the last item.

- We'll need to get flour, tomatoes, and cheese at the store.

Usage varies: the book always puts a comma before *and* in a list (the serial comma). Many newspapers and much British writing leave it out (flour, tomatoes and cheese). In this course, follow the book.

3. Between coordinating adjectives

Put a comma after every coordinating adjective except the last one: there is no comma between the last adjective and the noun. Unlike a list of nouns, a string of adjectives does not always need *and*.

- It was a bright, windy, clear day.
- Our kite glowed red, yellow, and blue in the morning sunlight.

A quick test: if you could put *and* between the adjectives (a bright and windy and clear day), use commas. If *and* sounds wrong, do not use a comma there.

4. Before FANBOYS in a compound sentence

independent clause + **comma** + for / and / nor / but / or / yet / so + independent clause

- He missed class today, and he thinks he will be out tomorrow, too.

The comma goes before the conjunction. A comma alone between two independent clauses is a comma splice (Lesson 04).

5. Around interrupting words

- At the beginning of a sentence, a comma follows them: Luckily, some people questioned that theory.
- In the middle, a comma goes before and after them: An Italian astronomer, Galileo, proved that Earth orbited the sun.
- To find the commas, look for the part that is not essential: the sentence still makes sense without it.

6. Dates, addresses, greetings and closings

What you write	Rule	Example
month, day and year	comma between the day and the year	The letter is postmarked May 4, 2001.
month and day, or month and year	no comma	Her birthday is May 5. / He visited the country in July 2009.
full date, sentence continues	comma after the year too	I registered for the conference on March 7, 2010, so we should get our tickets soon.
address in a sentence	comma after the street and after the city; none between the state and the zip code	We moved to 4542 Boxcutter Lane, Hope, Missouri 70832.
city and state, sentence continues	comma after the state too	After moving to Boston, Massachusetts, Eric used public transportation to get to work.
greeting and closing	comma after each	Hello, / Dear Mrs. Al-Sayf, / Thank you, / Sincerely,

These are American formats. When the day comes before the month (7 March 2010), no comma is used. A business letter may also use a colon after the greeting (Lesson 07).

7. Before a quotation

- Mark Twain said it best, "When in doubt, tell the truth."
- A quotation of 40 words or more (some say four lines) is a **block quotation**: introduce it with a comma, start it on a new line, indent it, and leave out the quotation marks.

Psychology note: APA style, which psychology uses, also requires the serial comma and sets quotations of 40 words or more as block quotations.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - In Arabic writing, it is normal to join one complete sentence to the next with a comma or with *and*, so sentences can be very long. In English, a comma alone cannot join two independent clauses: use a comma + FANBOYS, a semicolon (Lesson 07) or a period.

Practice

The exercises in the lesson material have no numbers; here they are numbered in the order they appear. Copy each sentence and add the commas.

Exercise 1. Introductory words and phrases.

1. Suddenly the dog ran into the house.
2. In the blink of an eye the kids were ready to go to the movies.
3. Confused he tried opening the box from the other end.
4. Every year we go camping in the woods.
5. Without a doubt green is my favorite color.
6. Hesitating she looked back at the directions before proceeding.
7. Fortunately the sleeping baby did not stir when the doorbell rang.
8. Believe it or not the criminal was able to rob the same bank three times.

Exercise 2. Lists and coordinating adjectives.

1. Monday Tuesday and Wednesday are all booked with meetings.
2. It was a quiet uneventful unproductive day.
3. We'll need to prepare statements for the Trumps Kardasians and Clintons before their portfolio reviews next week.
4. Donald Kim and Hillary finished their report last Tuesday.
5. With cold wet aching fingers he was able to secure the sails before the storm.
6. He wrote his name on the board in clear precise delicate letters.

Exercise 3. Compound sentences. Combine the two independent clauses with a comma and a coordinating conjunction.

1. The presentation was scheduled for Monday. The weather delayed the presentation for four days.
2. He wanted a snack before bedtime. He ate some fruit.
3. The patient is in the next room. I can hardly hear anything.
4. We could go camping for vacation. We could go to the beach for vacation.
5. I want to get a better job. I am taking courses at night.
6. I've got to get this paper done. I have class in ten minutes.
7. The weather was clear yesterday. We decided to go on a picnic.
8. I have never dealt with this client before. I know Leonardo has worked with them. Let's ask Leonardo for his help.

Exercise 4. Interrupting words.

1. I asked my neighbors the retired couple from Florida to bring in my mail.
2. Without a doubt his work has improved over the last few weeks.
3. Our professor Mr. Alamut drilled the lessons into our heads.

4. The meeting is at noon unfortunately which means I will be late for lunch.
5. We came in time for the last part of dinner but most importantly we came in time for dessert.
6. All of a sudden our network crashed and we lost our files.
7. Alex hand the wrench to me before the pipe comes loose again.

Exercise 5. A letter. Edit Alexa Marché's letter to Mr. Timmons in the lesson material (it begins "March 27 2010").

Exercise 6. Four paragraphs. Edit the four short paragraphs in the lesson material: 1. "My brother Nathaniel ..." 2. "Our meeting is scheduled ..." 3. "It was a cool crisp autumn day ..." 4. "Please have your report ..."

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me ten new sentences without commas, at least one for each comma rule in this lesson. I will add the commas and name the rule for each one."
- "Explain the difference between 'My brother, Nathaniel, is a collector' and 'My brother Nathaniel is a collector'. Then test me with three more pairs like this."
- "Here is a paragraph from my psychology notes: [paste]. Mark every comma error with a number and the rule, but let me correct them."
- "Check my answers to Exercises 5 and 6 in the lesson material: [paste]."

Read aloud

Make a short pause at each comma.

1. The barn, the tool shed, and the back porch were destroyed by the wind.
2. The bedroom door was closed, so the children knew their mother was asleep.
3. An Italian astronomer, Galileo, proved that Earth orbited the sun.
4. I registered for the conference on March 7, 2010, so we should get our tickets soon.
5. Mark Twain said it best, "When in doubt, tell the truth."

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 150 to 200 words on one of these topics:

- how you prepare for an important exam or deadline;
- a topic from PSYC 110, for example how sleep affects memory, or how people cope with stress;
- an e-mail to a professor or researcher asking for a short meeting (with a date, a greeting and a closing).

Use every comma rule at least once, including a full date and a short quotation (for example a sentence from a PSYC 110 lecture).

Checklist:

- Every introductory word or phrase is followed by a comma.
- Every list of three or more items has commas, with a comma before *and*.
- Coordinating adjectives have commas between them, but not after the last one.
- In each compound sentence, the comma comes before the FANBOYS word; no two independent clauses are joined by a comma alone.
- Interrupting words in the middle of a sentence have a comma on both sides.
- The full date has a comma between the day and the year, and after the year if the sentence continues.
- The quotation is introduced with a comma, and the period is inside the closing quotation marks.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

The book gives no key; these answers follow the book's rules. Only the part of each sentence with the new commas is shown.

Exercise 1

1. Suddenly, the dog ...
2. In the blink of an eye, the kids ...
3. Confused, he tried ...
4. Every year, we go ... (After a short introductory phrase like this, many writers leave out the comma; the book uses it.)
5. Without a doubt, green ...
6. Hesitating, she looked ...
7. Fortunately, the sleeping baby ...
8. Believe it or not, the criminal ...

Exercise 2

1. Monday, Tuesday, and Wednesday ...
2. a quiet, uneventful, unproductive day
3. the Trumps, Kardasians, and Clintons (The family name is usually spelled Kardashians.)
4. Donald, Kim, and Hillary ...
5. With cold, wet, aching fingers, he ... (The last comma ends the introductory phrase.)
6. in clear, precise, delicate letters

Exercise 3 (another conjunction is also correct if the meaning is logical)

1. ...for Monday, but the weather delayed ... (*yet* also works.)
2. ...before bedtime, so he ate some fruit.
3. ...in the next room, but I can hardly hear anything. (= it is surprisingly quiet; *yet* also works.) Or: ..., so I can hardly hear anything. (= the wall stops the sound.) Both are correct, with different meanings.
4. ...for vacation, or we could go to the beach ...
5. ...a better job, so I am taking courses at night.
6. ...this paper done, for I have class in ten minutes. (*for* = because; *and* or *but* is also possible.)
7. ...clear yesterday, so we decided ...
8. I have never dealt with this client before, but I know Leonardo has worked with them, so let's ask Leonardo for his help. (Or keep the last sentence separate: ...worked with them. Let's ask Leonardo for his help.)

Exercise 4

1. my neighbors, the retired couple from Florida, to bring in ...

2. Without a doubt, his work ...
3. Our professor, Mr. Alamut, drilled ...
4. ...at noon, unfortunately, which means ...
5. ...the last part of dinner, but, most importantly, we came ... (Many writers leave out the comma after *but*.)
6. All of a sudden, our network crashed, and we lost our files. (The second comma comes before *and* in a compound sentence.)
7. Alex, hand the wrench ... (The name of the person you speak to is set off with a comma.)

Exercise 5 March 27, 2010 / Alexa Marché / 14 Taylor Drive, Apt. 6 / New Castle, Maine 90342 / Dear Mr. Timmons, / ... I am available on Monday, the fifth. ... Is your address still 7309 Marcourt Circle, #501? ... / Thank you, / Alexa (The commas before *Apt. 6* and *#501* follow the rule "comma after the street"; some writers leave them out. *Dear Mr. Timmons:* is also correct in a business letter.)

Exercise 6

1. My brother, Nathaniel, is ... many rare, unusual things. ... lunch boxes, limited edition books, and hatpins ... Usually, he sells ... (Without commas, *My brother Nathaniel* means you have more than one brother; both are correct, with different meanings.)
2. ...for Thursday, March 20. In that time, we need ... To prepare for this meeting, please print out any e-mails, faxes, or documents ...
3. It was a cool, crisp autumn day ... (no comma before *autumn*: "crisp and autumn day" sounds wrong). ...before they made camp, so they walked ... The leader of the group, Garth, kept ... Isabelle, Raoul, and Maggie took turns ... As a result, no one noticed ...
4. ...by April 15, 2010. In your submission letter, please include your contact information, the position you are applying for, and two people ... after April 10, but you may contact ... Thank you, HR Department.

My notes